

# Japan, *February 2027*

Three weeks across Tokyo, the mountains, Kyoto's old streets, and a snow week in Nozawa. Nine of us, three generations, one big birthday.

|            |        |       |
|------------|--------|-------|
| DATES      | NIGHTS | OF US |
| 2 — 25 Feb | 23     | 9     |

## The crew

|                        |              |             |
|------------------------|--------------|-------------|
| Dad<br>The 70-year-old | Mum          | Gray        |
| Sophie                 | Jess         | Ben         |
| Florence<br>9          | Juniper<br>6 | Goldie<br>2 |

## The shape of the trip

Land late, ease in. A buffer for jetlag, body clocks, and the toddler. Big-city anchor experiences before we head into the mountains.

- Tue 2 **TRAVEL** Brisbane → Tokyo Narita, lands **17:30**. Transfer to hotel (~90 min). Conbini / hotel dinner — likely settled by 21:00.
- Wed 3 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Kappabashi-dori** kitchen town (knives, ceramics, plastic food samples). Afternoon: **Setsubun at Sensō-ji** — bean-throwing festival, oni costumes.
- Thu 4 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Tsukiji Outer Market** — sashimi breakfast, market wander. Afternoon: **Hama-rikyu Gardens** + tea house on the pond island.
- Fri 5 **ANCHOR** **Sumo morning practice** (6:30am, adult split-cohort, Ryōgoku). Afternoon: depachika browse (Mitsukoshi / Isetan). Early night before Hakone.

**BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME**

**STATIONERY** **Itoya Ginza** — 13 floors of pens, washi, art supplies. Tokyo's stationery temple.

**KIDS** **Pokemon Cafe + Pokemon Center DX (Nihonbashi)** — Pokemon HQ. Cafe needs ~1 month advance booking.

**CHAOS** **Don Quijote (Akihabara or Shibuya)** — multi-floor discount megastore, snacks, weird stuff, tax-free.

**ARCHITECTURE** **Sumida Hokusai Museum** — Kazuyo Sejima building + Hokusai prints. Pairs with Tsukiji morning.

**WHISKY** **Bar Zoetrope (Shinjuku)** — 300+ Japanese whiskies, adult evening.

**NIGHTLIFE** **Golden Gai (Shinjuku)** — six tiny alleys of 4–8 seat bars, adults only.

**HANDS-ON** **Buaisou indigo workshop (Kuramae)** — traditional aizome dyeing, take a tote home.

LEG 02 · 2 NIGHTS

## Hakone

Sat 6 — Mon 8 Feb

Onsen town. Mt Fuji views, volcanic valleys, and the slow-down day before Kyoto.

Sat 6

TRAVEL

Tokyo → Hakone on Odakyu Romancecar (~85 min). Lunch in Yumoto.  
Afternoon: **Hakone Open-Air Museum**. Check in to ryokan, onsen + kaiseki dinner.

Sun 7

ANCHOR

**The Hakone Loop** — Tozan switchback railway → cable car → ropeway over Owakudani (volcanic valley, black eggs) → pirate ship across Lake Ashi (Fuji views) → Hakone Shrine (torii in the water) → bus back.

### BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

ART

**Pola Museum of Art** — Impressionists in a forest setting, walk-able from the ropeway.

PHOTOGENIC

**Hakone Glass Forest (Venetian Glass Museum)** — kid-friendly, very pretty.

The cultural heart and the depth leg. Eight nights to slow right down — temples, machiya streets, sake breweries, master craft. Wide day-trip range: Himeji, Nara, Fushimi sake, Yamazaki distillery, Osaka half-day, Kaiyukan aquarium.

- Mon 8 **TRAVEL** Hakone → Kyoto via shinkansen (~2 hr 15). Check in.
- Tue 9 **ANCHOR** **Higashiyama / Gion day** — Kiyomizu-dera, Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka, Yasaka Shrine, Gion wander. Optional free walking tour in the morning.
- Wed 10 **ANCHOR** **Fushimi day** — Inari shrine 1000 torii morning, Fushimi sake district afternoon (Gekkeikan museum + tasting, Kizakura).
- Thu 11 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Nara half-day** — Tōdai-ji giant Buddha + deer park. Afternoon back in Kyoto.
- Fri 12 **ANCHOR** **Himeji Castle day trip** (~50 min shinkansen). Keep climb + Koko-en gardens. Split-cohort if Goldie skips the keep.
- Sat 13 **ANCHOR** **Kids day** — Toei Kyoto Studio Park (samurai film set, ninja shows, costume dress-up) + Kyoto Railway Museum.
- Sun 14 **ANCHOR** Yamazaki + Kaiyukan day — split cohort, adults distillery / kids aquarium.
- Mon 15 **FREE** Morning: **forward bags to Nozawa via Yamato Takkyubin** (arrives Tue). Afternoon: free / last Kyoto wander.

#### BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

**FOOD** **Nishiki Market** — "Kyoto's kitchen," covered food street, snack as you walk.

**NIGHTLIFE** **Pontocho alley** — narrow lantern-lit alley packed with restaurants and bars after dark.

**FOOD** **Kichi Kichi omurice** — theatrical chef-as-show omurice (the famous YouTube one). Book ahead.

**CALENDAR GIFT** **Plum blossom at Kitano Tenmangu** — ~1,500 plum trees in peak bloom mid-Feb. Plum tea house in the grounds.

**CULTURE** **Tea ceremony with a master** — proper sit-down, ~90 min. Operators: Camellia, En, Hozan-ji.

**KIMONO** **Kimono dress-up in Gion** — get dressed and photographed in old Kyoto streets.

**BAMBOO** **Arashiyama half-day** — bamboo grove + Tenryū-ji + Togetsukyo bridge. Skip the monkey park.

**TEMPLE** **Saiho-ji Moss Temple** — advance postal reservation only, sutra-copying meditation, otherworldly.

## Nozawa Onsen

Tue 16 — Sun 21 Feb

The snow week. Skiing for those who want it, 13 free public bathhouses, and Sparena for the lower-pressure mixed-bathing option. Nozawa Dream Central is the target accommodation.

- |        |        |                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tue 16 | TRAVEL | Kyoto → Tokyo → Iiyama → Nozawa (~5 hr door-to-door). Daypacks only — bags arrive separately. <b>9am Kyoto → ~2:30pm Nozawa.</b> Check in, onsen, settle. |
| Wed 17 | ANCHOR | <b>Ski day 1.</b> Girls in lessons. Non-skiers: village + Sparena + Sakaya Honten sake.                                                                   |
| Thu 18 | ANCHOR | <b>Ski day 2.</b> Non-skiers optional <b>Nagano + Obuse</b> day-trip (Zenkō-ji, Hokusai Museum, Masuichi-Ichimura sake).                                  |
| Fri 19 | ANCHOR | <b>Ski day 3.</b> Non-skiers: village + onsen + relaxed pace.                                                                                             |
| Sat 20 | FREE   | <b>Chill day.</b> Onsen, Sparena, slow village wander, pack. Everyone wind-down.                                                                          |

Back to the city for the wind-down. The sushi-counter dinner. The last surprise. The slow re-pack.

- Sun 21

TRAVEL

Nozawa → Tokyo (~2.5–3 hr door-to-door). 9am Nozawa → ~12:30pm Tokyo. Daypacks only — bags forwarded Sat.
- Mon 22

ANCHOR

**Dad's golf day** — Ginza morning (Honma + Mizuno flagships), Kanda Ogawamachi afternoon (Victoria Golf + sports street browse).
- Tue 23

ANCHOR

Morning: **Ghibli Museum** (Mitaka — book tickets 10am JST on 10 Jan 2027). Evening: **Dad's birthday dinner** — sushi counter.
- Wed 24

ANCHOR

**teamLab Planets** (Toyosu — barefoot water immersive) + **Small Worlds Tokyo** (Ariake — model city park, get inserted as figurines).

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

- VIEW

Shibuya Sky — 230m glass-edged open-air observation deck. Sunset is the play.
- STATIONERY

Kakimori (Kuramae) — make-your-own notebook + custom ink at Inkstand next door. Reddit favourite.
- ART

Yayoi Kusama Museum — Kusama deep dive. Lottery booking opens 2 months ahead.
- DESIGN

21\_21 Design Sight (Tadao Ando, Midtown) — rotating design exhibitions.
- WALK

Yanaka old-town — quiet residential Tokyo, narrow lanes, less touristy.
- SUB-CULTURE

Nakano Broadway — multi-floor anime/manga/used goods. Mandarake flagship inside.
- BEER

Yebisu Beer Museum — small museum + tasting bar, dad-coded half-day.

● Travel day ● Anchor day ● Free day

Where we're at

## LOCKED IN

Flights (Brisbane → Narita, 2 Feb 17:30)

Nozawa dates (16–21 Feb)

5-leg itinerary shape

Osaka cut — Yamazaki, Kaiyukan, Castle as Kyoto day-trips

## OPEN THREADS

Nozawa Dream Central — confirm dates + breakfast

Accommodation per leg (9 of us)

Activity bookings (Yamazaki, sushi, etc.)

Share with the family group